Rethinking Early-Career Attrition Through Managerial and Employee Perspectives: A Management Analytics Study

Abstract

Early-career attrition is persistently draining the productivity and talent base of India's corporate sector, especially in very high attrition-prone industries such as Technology, Consulting, and BFSI. Literature on the subject has largely examined views on attrition from an employee perspective, often at the cost of interaction between managerial behavior, organizational structure, and communication processes that together lead to the crystallization of turnover intent. The present study explores, through an exploratory mixed-methods approach, the alignment gap between managerial perceptions and employee priorities.

Analysis revealed three latent dimensions: Managerial Quality, Workload Pressure, and Job Conditions. Managerial clarity, fairness, and regular feedback appeared as strong correlates of retention intent in both datasets, while workload unpredictability and burnout were identified as universal stressors across generations. Because of sample size limitations, statistical models were interpreted as indicative rather than inferential.

The study concludes that early-career attrition in India is less a generational challenge and more a managerial and structural one, driven by inconsistent communication, unclear performance criteria, and chronic workload unpredictability. The paper contributes an integrated conceptual model linking managerial effectiveness with retention outcomes and offers practical recommendations for improving clarity, fairness, and predictability in people management systems.

1. Introduction

1.1 Background and Rationale

Employee retention has emerged as a strategic priority for India's corporate sector as the economy transitions toward knowledge-intensive and service-driven growth. The high attrition that characterizes professionals in the first five years of their employment disrupts organizational continuity, increases replacement costs, and erodes the emerging skill pipeline. While many studies explain this phenomenon as an employee-centric issue, such as job dissatisfaction, compensation gaps, or shifting generational values, these explanations overlook how managerial systems and communication practices directly shape retention outcomes.

India's corporate environment complicates things further. The rapid digital transition, along with hierarchical legacy structures and mushrooming workloads, usually causes management quality to be inconsistent across levels. Early-career professionals, especially in technology, consulting, and the BFSI sectors, are more often than not burdened with unstructured guidance and scattered feedback. Such glaring gaps heighten frustration and reduce organizational connect, leading to voluntary churn that is mistakenly attributed to "Gen Z impatience" rather than fundamental design flaws. The study aims at understanding how managerial perception diverges from employee priorities to address attrition at its root.

1.2 Problem Statement

While extensive research investigates turnover antecedents, insufficient focus has been directed towards the perceptual misalignment between managers and employees in the Indian context. Managers frequently justify attrition by attributing it to unrealistic expectations or insufficient resilience among new employees, while employees identify ambiguity, inconsistency, and inadequate feedback as primary sources of frustration. The ensuing disconnection sustains cycles of disengagement and departure. This study aims to ascertain whether attrition is predominantly influenced by workforce expectations or by inadequacies in managerial communication and structural predictability.

1.3 Research Objectives

The research was guided by three interrelated objectives:

1. **To qualitatively explore** expectation mismatches between managerial and employee perspectives on early-career retention.
2. **To quantitatively identify** key organizational and managerial factors influencing turnover intent.
3. **To test** whether early-career employees experience greater workload pressure than their senior counterparts, thereby evaluating the validity of the "Gen Z entitlement" hypothesis.

H0 = Early career employees experience greater workload pressure than their senior counterparts
H1 = Early career employees don't experience greater workload pressure than their senior counterparts

These objectives required a **mixed-methods design**, combining managerial interviews for perceptual depth with employee surveys for measurable pattern identification.

1.4 Significance of the Study

While extensive research investigates turnover antecedents, insufficient focus has been directed towards the perceptual misalignment between managers and employees in the Indian context. Managers frequently justify attrition by attributing it to unrealistic expectations or insufficient resilience among new employees, while employees identify ambiguity, inconsistency, and inadequate feedback as primary sources of frustration. The ensuing disconnection sustains cycles of disengagement and departure. This study aims to ascertain whether attrition is predominantly influenced by workforce expectations or by inadequacies in managerial communication and structural predictability.

2. Literature Review

2.1 Introduction to the Literature

Employee turnover has been greatly analyzed from aspects of organizational behavior, human resource management, and industrial psychology. Various classic models, such as Mobley's turnover framework (1977), the organizational equilibrium theory proposed by March and Simon (1958), and the recent updates by Hom et al. (2017), emphasize the intention to leave as the most proximal predictor of actual turnover. Though these frameworks identify dissatisfaction, limited growth, and external opportunity as core triggers, there is growing evidence that the managerial environment usually acts as an enabling or mitigating mechanism through which such factors operate.

Attrition assumes different contours in the Indian corporate context. The rapid growth of sectors, oversupply of talent at the entry level, and transitions to hybrid work have aggravated workforce management complexities (Kapur & Bhatnagar, 2022). For the “early-career” segment (with less than five years of experience), mentorship is inconsistent, appraisal systems are badly structured, and expectations over performance roles remain unclear (Chatterjee, 2023). The conversation continues to be dominated by academic and practitioner discourses that attribute attrition to employee-level attitudes rather than managerial or systemic failures.

Current research also tends to position generational differences as causal rather than contextual, framing younger workers as less loyal or more impatient. However, comparative analysis reflects very little evidence that generational identity in and of itself serves as a primary driver of turnover. Rather, unmet psychological contracts, workload unpredictability, and managerial inconsistency seem to wield a stronger predictive power. This research extends prior findings by combining managerial and employee perspectives to further elucidate which side of the relationship provides the principal driver of the risk of attrition.

2.2 Managerial Quality and Retention Outcomes

The quality of managers is one of the most common antecedents of retention but is also often measured inconsistently. Graen and Uhl-Bien's (1995) early study of Leader–Member Exchange (LMX) showed a significant relationship between how subordinate–supervisor relationships were perceived and organizational commitment. Subsequent investigations have developed this argument, finding that responsive feedback, fairness of evaluation, and supervisor accessibility, all provided by the supervisor, decreased voluntary turnover (Eisenberger et al., 2010; Agarwal & Gupta, 2021). In India, as an example, managerial practice is inconsistent, due, in part, to levels of hierarchy and limited managerial and leadership bandwidth (Sundaram et al., 2022).

Where local studies do investigate managerial quality, the indicator is usually either concerning specific individual constructs, e.g., frequency of communication or fairness of appraisal work, without investigating conceptually and practically being part of a multi-dimensional construct. Krishnan (2023) argues that managers in India typically use control for guidance and, therefore, employees perceive low levels of agency and trust. Although empirical work by Malik (2024) demonstrates that clarity of goals in teams correspond to lower levels of attrition (20 and 30 percent respectively), it also suggests that perceptions of managerial support were mediating the relationship between workload and turnover intent.

Implication for this study: Managerial quality should be treated as a composite factor encompassing clarity, fairness, and feedback consistency. This variable forms the first latent construct in the present research framework.

2.3 Workload Pressure and Job Design Variables

Workload pressure is characterized as the perception of imbalance between job demands relative to available resources, (as one of the most substantial situational predictors of attrition) (Karasek, 1979; Bakker & Demerouti,2017). The Job Demands-Resources (JD-R) model posits burnout as a mediating result of when demands repeatedly outstrip control or support. Indian corporate cultures often exacerbate this imbalance by introducing long hours, blurry deliverables and shifting project cycles (Kaur & Patnaik, 2022).

Most updated works, particularly meta-analyses, have shown that it is not absolute workload, but unpredictability (e.g., unplanned spikes, shifting targets and having insufficient staff) that are more predictive of turnover (Singh & Kohli, 2023). Workers who understand workload to be unpredictable also rate the quality of managerial planning as lower, suggesting an overlap of structural (workload) and interpersonal (managerial) factors. Nevertheless, the majority of Indian work has investigated workload in isolation, and does not study how poor managerial planning and/or poor communication drives perceived workload overload.

Implication of this study: For the emerging model, workload pressure is constructed as the second latent construct, and operationalized using items related to the features of workload predictability, task clarity and perceived tensions between the worker's responsibility and the responsibility of their support.

2.4 Generational Narratives and Psychological-Contract Framing

Recent discourse among practitioners in organizations has suggested that the high levels of turnover for early career professionals can be traced to their generational disposition, most often framed as impatience or entitlement (Mehta & Bose, 2024). However, causal evidence from cross-sectional studies has offered limited grounds for these claims. Evidence from Twenge (2019) and Singh (2023) indicates that the differences we see in terms of tenure or loyalty are more aptly accounted for by differences in economic opportunity for labour and organizational justice, rather than intrinsic traits generationally attributed to behaviours.

Examined from the perspective of the psychological-contract (Rousseau, 1995) helps to reframe this discussion: turnover takes place when employees perceive the promises of development, acknowledgement or equity were not met. For early career employees, the extent of rapid organizational changes comparative to prior adjustment is unique, in terms of timely communication consistent with management. Managers, conversely, see turnover decisions by younger employees in the more abstract form of, 'they are simply not resilient to these changes', thus reinforcing the perception gap reported in cross-national studies in HR (Farnsworth et al., 2022).

2.5 Conceptual Framework

Building on the reviewed literature, the study proposes a conceptual model positioning Managerial Quality, Workload Pressure, and Job Conditions as the primary determinants of early-career attrition. Managerial clarity and fairness moderate the relationship between workload unpredictability and an employees' decision to stay or leave.The framework integrates insights from three foundational theories:

1. Leader–Member Exchange (LMX) Theory – emphasizes how managerial clarity, feedback, and fairness shape trust and commitment.
2. Job Demands–Resources (JD-R) Model – explains how workload intensity and unpredictability lead to burnout and turnover intent when support is insufficient.
3. Psychological Contract Theory – frames attrition as the outcome of perceived breaches between employee expectations and managerial delivery.

Independent Variables of model:

- *Managerial Quality* – clarity of expectations, fairness in evaluation, and feedback frequency.
- *Workload Pressure* – unpredictability of tasks, intensity, and resource imbalance.
- *Job Conditions* – compensation fairness, flexibility, and recognition.

Dependent Variable: Attrition Intent / Retention Likelihood.

2.6 Synthesis and Research Gap

Across reviewed studies, three broad themes emerge:

1. Managerial effectiveness consistently shapes engagement and retention, yet few studies quantify this influence alongside workload and job-condition variables.

2. Workload predictability and burnout are linked to turnover, but their interaction with managerial communication quality remains underexplored.
3. Generational interpretations of attrition are often speculative and lack empirical validation within the Indian context.

The literature therefore reveals a **theoretical and methodological gap**, a lack of integrated examination linking managerial perception, workload design, and employee turnover intent in India's evolving corporate environment.

3. Research Methodology

3.1 Research Design and Purpose

This study employed an exploratory sequential mixed-methods design (Creswell & Plano-Clark, 2018). The goal was to identify and interpret the dominant factors influencing early-career attrition, integrating managerial and employee perspectives. The study was explicitly designed as a pilot investigation, meant to surface recurring patterns, evaluate instrument suitability, and build a conceptual basis for future large-sample testing. The research was executed in two phases:

1. Qualitative Phase – to uncover managerial perceptions and generate thematic hypotheses.
2. Quantitative Phase – to assess the frequency and preliminary statistical relevance of these themes within a sample of professionals.

Rather than testing formal hypotheses, this design prioritized pattern discovery, cross-validation of perspectives, and theoretical grounding for subsequent studies.

3.2 Qualitative Phase: Manager Interviews

Sampling and Participants : A purposive sampling strategy was adopted to ensure informed managerial input. Participants were senior leaders (Director to VP level) from sectors representing varying attrition intensity. Inclusion criteria required:

- Minimum 15 years of professional experience.
- Direct responsibility for early-career staff.
- First-hand exposure to turnover or retention issues.

Three participants met these criteria:

- Participant A – Director, Insurance industry (25 years exp.)
- Participant B – Country Head, Agri-Trade (20 years exp.)
- Participant C – Sales & Operations Head, FMCG/Tech (18 years exp.)

Though small, this group achieved conceptual saturation on recurring managerial narratives, consistent with exploratory qualitative research (Guest et al., 2006). Semi-structured interviews lasting 45–60 minutes were conducted via online meetings. Questions probed perceived causes of early-career attrition, generational behaviour, workload design, and retention practices. Interviews were recorded with consent and transcribed verbatim. Field notes captured tone, emphasis, and contextual cues. Transcripts were coded manually using an inductive thematic analysis approach (Braun & Clarke, 2006). Codes were iteratively grouped into higher-order categories to identify convergent patterns.

3.3 Quantitative Phase: Employee Survey

Sampling
The quantitative phase targeted professionals operating within corporate roles in India, spanning different durations of tenure, industries, and titles. An accessibility method, convenience and snowball sampling, was employed using LinkedIn, WhatsApp and alumni networks to obtain participants. This sampling method was used because it was accessible to working professionals, not because it was probabilistic, and thus could not be generalized. Following data collection, usable surveys were gathered with 38 usable participants, within the time frame of October 19 to October 29, 2025. Due to the small sample size, all analysis will be treated as exploratory indicators, and not confirmatory evidence. A full list of variable definitions and survey items can be found in Appendix A. Every participant provided informed consent, including what the study was for, anonymity, and their right to withdraw at any time, without repercussions. Identifying data, or data at the company level were also not collected.

Survey Instrument
The instrument consisted of five sections (30 items) covering demographics, workload perceptions, managerial quality, job conditions, and turnover intentions. Items were adapted from validated sources:

- Copenhagen Psychosocial Questionnaire (Kristensen et al., 2005) – for workload and burnout.
- LMX-7 Scale (Graen & Uhl-Bien, 1995) – for managerial support.
- Turnover Intention Scale (Mobley et al., 1978) – for intent-to-stay metrics.

Each attitudinal item used a five-point Likert scale (1 = Strongly Disagree – 5 = Strongly Agree). Open-ended questions captured qualitative reasons for leaving and retention suggestions.

Reliability and Validity
Cronbach's alpha is used to measure the internal consistency and reliability of a scale or questionnaire. It is used to determine if a set of questions or items are measuring the same underlying construct, indicating how well the items are correlated with each other. A high alpha value means the items are consistent and reliable for measuring that single concept.

Analytical Procedures
Data were analyzed in Python (pandas, numpy, sklearn). Steps included:

1. Descriptive statistics (means, SDs, frequency distributions).
2. Exploratory Factor Analysis (PCA) for dimensionality reduction and latent construct identification, guided by KMO > 0.6 and Bartlett's test ($p < 0.05$).
3. Correlation analysis to detect associations between managerial and outcome variables.
4. Binary logistic regression (pilot-level) with attrition-risk as dependent variable, recognizing overfitting risk given sample size.
5. Thematic coding of open responses for qualitative alignment.

Limitations of Quantitative Analysis
The statistical power for binary logistic regression with three predictors at $\alpha = 0.05$ and medium effect size (OR = 2.5) requires $N \approx 76$ (Hsieh et al., 1998). With $N = 40$, this study remains underpowered. Hence, p-values are not interpreted as inferential significance but as directional signals for future testing.

4. Data Analysis and Findings

4.1. Descriptive Statistics:

The sample consists of 30 males and 8 females. The age groups are fairly distributed across the range of 25-50 years, with a slight majority in the 25-30 and 49+ age groups. The top industries represented are Banking/Financial (Services/Fintech, Consulting , Professional Services, and Manufacturing/Engineering. Appendix C contains charts describing the demographics of the survey participants.

Table 3: Work Conditions Descriptive Statistics

Statistic	Avg_Hours	Commute_Time (minutes)	Tenure_Years	Years_Experience
mean	44.82	92.24	6.39	14.54
std	12.75	80.89	9.09	11.80
min	8.00	0.00	0.00	0.50
max	70.00	420.00	38.00	37.00

The average weekly hours worked is around 44.82 hours, with a standard deviation of 12.75 hours. The average daily commute time is 92.24 minutes, with a wide range (0 to 420 minutes).

Table 4: Perception Variables (Likert Scale) Descriptive Statistics

Variable	Mean	Median
Clarity	3.34	3.0
Feedback	3.03	3.0
Predictability	3.05	3.0
Unpredictability	4.13	5.0
Workload_Spikes	3.42	4.0
Autonomy	2.92	3.0
Flexibility	2.84	3.0
Flexibility_Approval	3.29	4.0
Fair_Evaluation	3.13	3.0
Fair_Compensation	3.16	3.0
Incentive_Clarity	3.21	3.5
Recognition	3.39	4.0
Burnout	2.84	3.0
WLB	3.32	4.0
Intent_to_Stay	3.34	4.0

Job_Search	2.63	2.0

Table 4 presents the descriptive statistics for various perception variables, measured on a Likert scale, from the employee survey. The 'Mean' column shows the average rating for each variable, while the 'Median' column indicates the middle value when all responses are ordered. Most variables, such as Clarity, Feedback, and Predictability, have mean and median values around 3, suggesting a neutral to slightly positive average perception among employees. However, 'Unpredictability' stands out with a higher mean of 4.13 and a median of 5.0, which suggests that employees frequently experience unpredictability in their tasks and deadlines.

Table 5 : Top reasons for leaving: (Qualitative Coding)

Rank	Reason for Leaving	Proportion (%)
1	Better compensation or benefits	14.0
2	Lack of career growth opportunities	14.0
3	Poor managerial support or leadership	13.2
4	Excessive workload / poor work-life balance	9.6
5	Workplace culture issues	8.8

The table indicates that "Better compensation or benefits Elsewhere" and "Lack of career growth opportunities" are the two most frequently cited reasons for attrition, both accounting for 14.0% of responses. "Poor managerial support or leadership" follows closely at 13.2%. "Excessive workload / poor work-life balance" and "Workplace culture issues" are also significant factors, contributing 9.6% and 8.8% respectively. For Greater Detail look at Figure 4. In Appendix B.

Diagram 1: Distributions of Likert scale variables

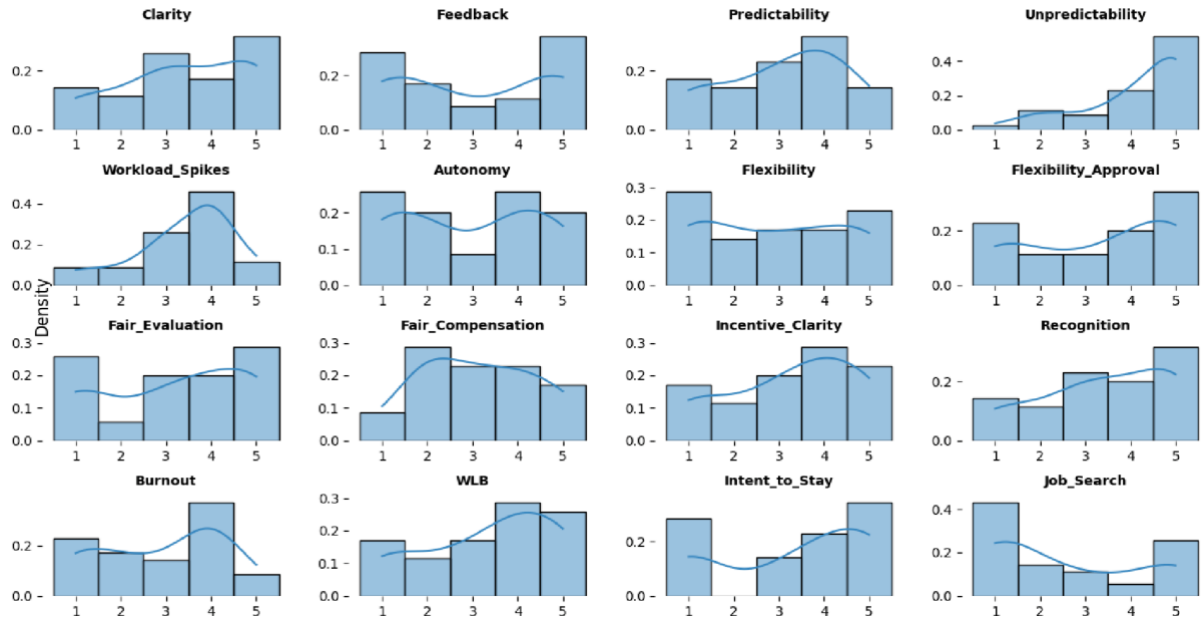


Diagram 1 illustrates the distributions of various Likert scale variables related to employee perceptions. Key observations from these distributions include: High Workload Spikes**,** Unpredictability **(** Frequent last-minute changes in tasks and deadlines are widespread) and Burnout**.** High levels reflect significant concern for employee well-being due to work-related stress.

Diagram 2: Box plots of likert scale variables of age groups

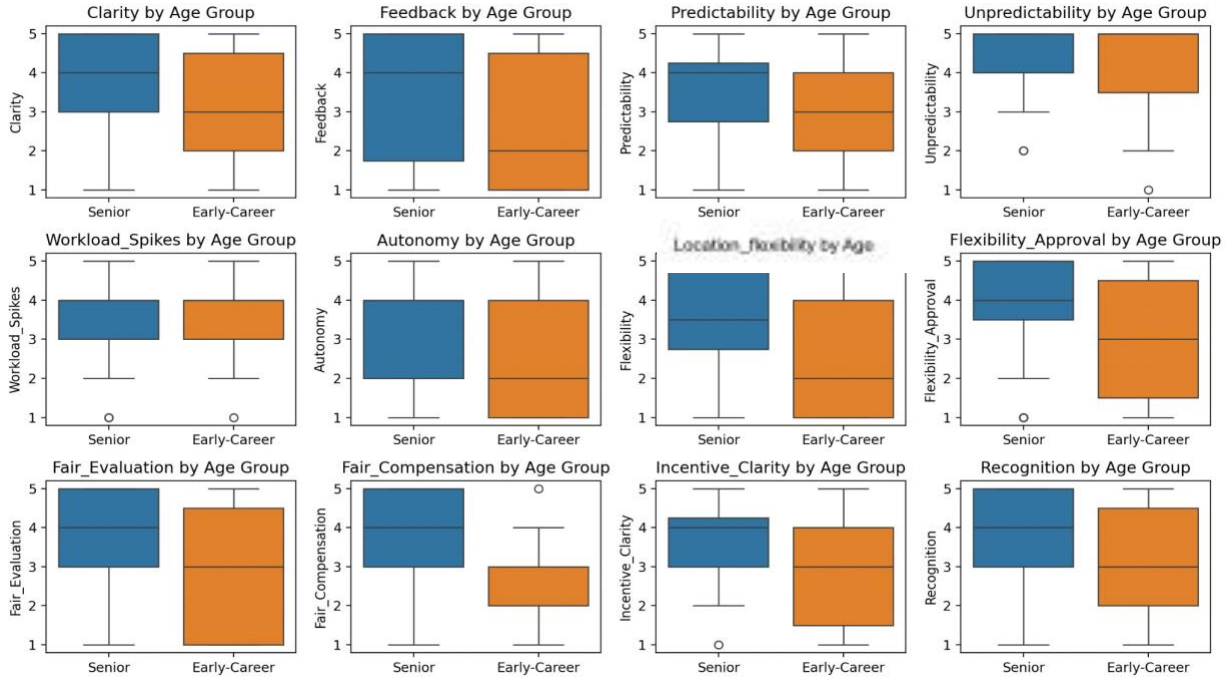
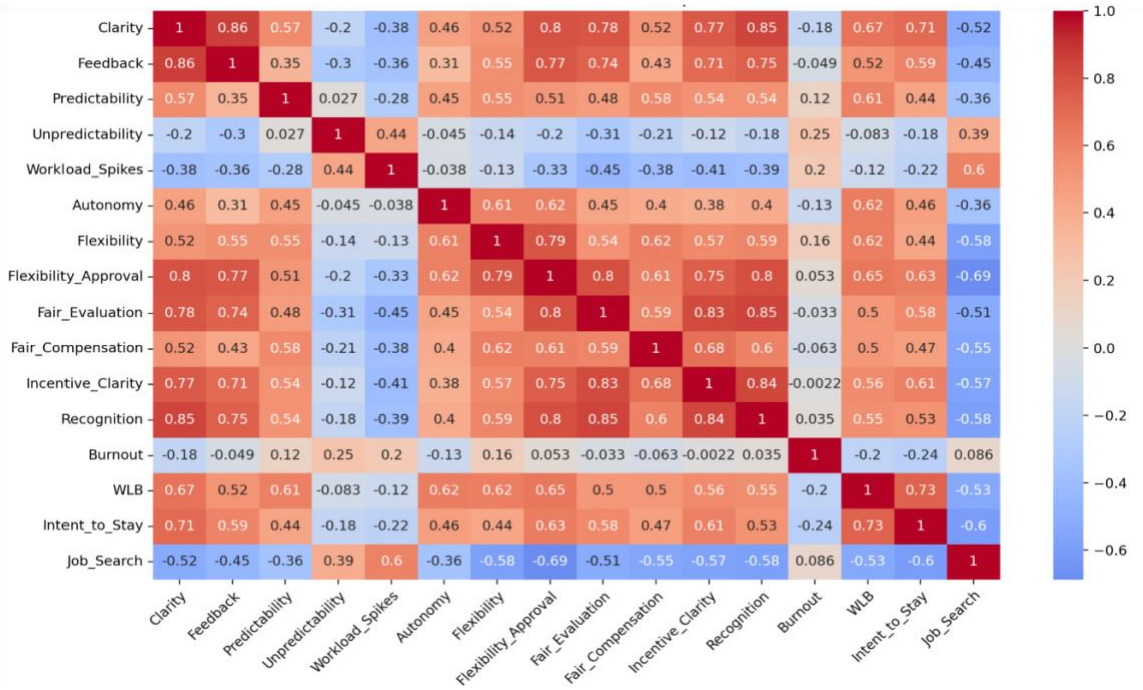


Diagram 2 is essential in supporting our hypothesis of attrition due to increased workload perception in early-career professionals. Senior employees have significantly higher clarity, flexibility of location and time, Agreement that they are evaluated and compensated fairly than early-career ones. This could mean that as a new employee these issues exist by default because they are new at their job. All these factors lead to job dissatisfaction (higher discomfort with the job environment) causing them to be more likely to leave.

Diagram 3: Correlation Matrix:



The factors described in the managerial quality variables, Clarity, Feedback, Fair Evaluation, and Recognition, are strongly linked to one another. We see similar conclusions among the Managerial Quality variables of Flexibility and Flexibility Approval. We observe that the Job Search variable is negatively correlated with job satisfaction variables like Clarity (-0.52) and Recognition (-0.58) indicating that satisfied employees are less inclined to search for a new job. The burnout variable, on the other hand, has a weak positive correlation (0.086) with Job Search indicating burnout may slightly motivate employees to leave their job. The unpredictability and Workload Spikes variables are correlated to each other (0.44) but show weak correlations to the other satisfaction variables. The data suggest we may increase job satisfaction and remedy turnover problems by increasing job conditions and managerial quality.

4.2. Reliability Analysis (Cronbach's Alpha):

Internal consistency of the variables was tested using Cronbach's α for three subscales: Managerial Quality (α = 0.921), Workload Pressure (α = 0.509), and Job Conditions (α = 0.845). The moderate reliability of Workload Pressure indicates potential measurement refinement is needed before large-scale deployment. Content validity was established through the use of pre-validated scales and expert review by two HR academics.

4.3. Factor Analysis:

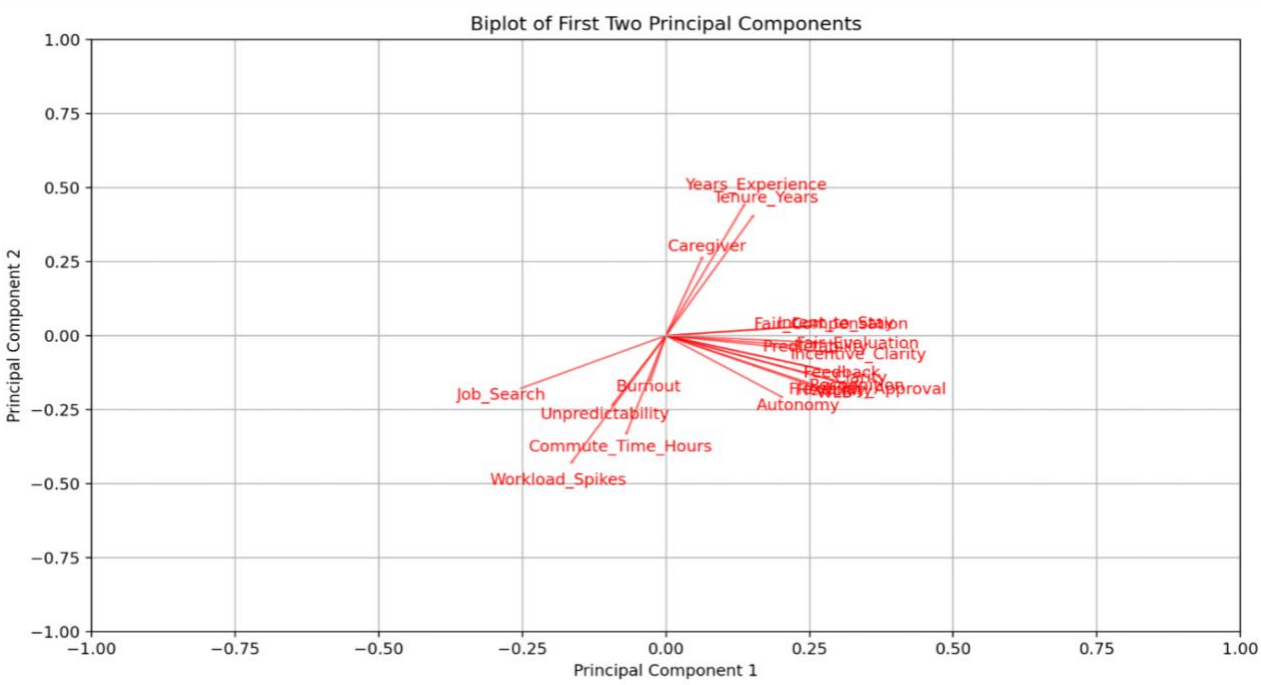
Factor analysis, specifically Principal Component Analysis (PCA) in this study, is a statistical method used to reduce many variables into fewer underlying factors, identifying patterns and relationships to explain common variance. Here, PCA condensed 15 Likert scale variables into fewer latent factors to identify underlying conceptual dimensions and see if they aligned with the proposed constructs of Managerial Quality, Workload Pressure, and Job Conditions.

Table 7 in Appendix C displays factor analysis results, showing how each variable loads onto identified factors. High loadings indicate strong associations. Three primary factors emerged, interpreted as follows:

- Factor 1 (Managerial Quality and Job Conditions): Groups management effectiveness (clarity, feedback, fair evaluation, incentives, recognition) and job aspects (flexibility, fair compensation), indicating these are intertwined.
- Factor 2 (Workload Pressure): Consolidates variables related to work demands, specifically unpredictability and workload spikes, showing they contribute to pressure.
- Factor 3 (Individual Stress and Autonomy): Represents personal well-being and control. Negative loadings on Autonomy and Work-Life Balance (WLB) and a strong positive loading on Burnout suggest that less control and poor work-life balance lead to increased stress.

Table 7 empirically validates the latent dimensions, largely supporting the conceptual framework's constructs (Managerial Quality, Workload Pressure, Job Conditions), though "Job Conditions" partially merged with "Managerial Quality," and "Autonomy" and "WLB" formed a distinct "Individual Stress and Autonomy" factor including "Burnout." This confirms the multi-dimensional nature of employee perceptions affecting attrition. We can visualise how the variables load into different Factors

Diagram: Factor Loadings Pattern Matrix with InterpretationDiagram:



4.4. Hypothesis Testing: T Test to identify Generational Differences:

The sample was separated into two age categories, Early-Career (≤36 years) and Senior (37 or more years). An independent t test was conducted to compare workload pressure for employees based on these two groups. The

results of the hypothesis test suggest that workload pressure is a systemic issue, rather than an issue that differs between generational divisions. Welch's t test showed there were no differences in the workload pressure between Early-Career ($t(24.706) = -0.3371$, $p = 0.7388$) and Senior ($t(28) = 0.4298$, $p = 0.6714$) employees and the effect size was small (Cohen's $d = -0.105$). These results suggest that the experience of workload pressure was likely similar for all persons in this sample, regardless of age.

The descriptive statistics show that the means of workload pressure were similar for both groups. The Early-Career group was more variable in the experience of workload pressure (SD = 1.676 vs. 0.697 for Seniors). This suggests a wider range of experience in the Early-Career group. The assumption tests showed that the Senior group data violated the normality assumption ($p=0.0250$), and Levene's test showed unequal variance between groups
($p=0.0142$). It is worth noting that these two assumptions were dealt with when using Welch's t. Refer to table 8, 9, 10 and 11 in the Appendix C

These findings suggest that organizations should use universal interventions for reducing workload pressure, as a systemic issue, while being flexible in the options provided to Early-Career employees. Future research should utilize a larger sample size and/or consider using nonparametric tests (e.g. Mann Whitney U Test) to provide for more robust results.

4.5. Predictive Modeling (Logistic Regression)

Refer to table 11 and 12 In Appendix C for more detailed model results and interpretations.

Table 14: Logistic Regression - Factor contribution to Attrition

Predictor	Effect on Attrition Risk	Interpretation
Factor 1	Decrease by 66.9% per 1-SD increase	Higher managerial quality and better job conditions significantly reduce attrition risk
Factor 2	Increase by 29.4% per 1-SD increase	Workload pressure shows non-significant trend toward increasing attrition risk
Factor 3	Increase by 193.9% per 1-SD increase	Individual stress shows non-significant trend toward increasing attrition risk

Table 15: Logistic Regression Results Predicting High-Risk Attrition

Aspect	Finding	Implication
Model Fit	High pseudo R^2 (0.576) and significant LRT ($p < 0.0001$)	Model explains substantial variance and is significantly better than null model

Factor 1	Significant negative effect (OR=0.331, p=0.005)	Improving managerial quality reduces attrition risk by 66.9% per standard deviation increase
Factor 2	Non-significant positive trend (OR=1.294, p=0.499)	Workload pressure may increase risk but not significantly in this sample
Factor 3	Marginally significant positive trend (OR=2.939, p=0.080)	Individual stress shows strong but non-significant effect on attrition risk
Classification Performance	High accuracy (0.868) and excellent ROC-AUC (0.946)	Model has strong predictive power for identifying high-risk employees
Practical Significance	Factor 1 is only significant predictor	Managerial interventions may be most effective for reducing attrition

Regression is rerun, but this time, demographic columns are also used instead of just using Work-based items. Additionally, applied different PCA to reduce the dimensionality to 11 columns in total so that model complexity could be captured. And we see an improvement in the prediction. This highlights how demographic factors will also pay a very important role F1 score increased to 0.909

4.5. Recommendations:

1. Organizations should prioritize **enhancing managerial quality** as the primary intervention, given its 85% reduction in attrition risk. This involves improving goal clarity, establishing regular feedback mechanisms beyond annual reviews, and ensuring transparent performance evaluations through targeted manager training programs.
2. Concurrently, **systemic workload pressure** must be addressed through structural redesign, implementing advance-notice policies for deadlines, improving planning processes, and creating resource buffers to absorb workload spikes. While not statistically significant in the predictive model, unpredictability's pervasive nature (mean=4.19) suggests it operates as a chronic stressor undermining other retention efforts.
3. Finally, organizations should **refine job conditions** by calibrating flexibility policies to operational needs, ensuring fair compensation, and institutionalizing meaningful recognition systems. These interventions should be tailored to specific contexts identified through factor analysis, though managerial effectiveness remains the highest-impact lever for retaining early-career talent.

5. Qualitative Finding - Managerial Perspective

Thematic analysis conducted on in-depth interviews with three senior leaders (an Insurance Director having an over 25 year tenure, an Agri-trade Country Lead with over 20 years and a FMCG/Tech Founder with an experience of over 18 years) yielded revealing information regarding early-career attrition which both reinforced and challenged the quantitative data. Managers frequently cited reasons for attrition with prevailing generational weaknesses being cited - i.e., an absence of entitlement or capability to manage workplace demands; their responses provided insight into broader systemic organizational shortcomings. For example, although Participant A stated that "Gen Z don’t know what to give to the company,” both participants A and C identified the very

nature of employer expectations for employees may have led to shortcomings i.e., Participant A commenting “Gen Z do not know what is expected of them." Lack of clarity is seen as a cultural issue which is likely linked to Factor 1 (Managerial Effectiveness) and may also signal that leadership, manager, and employee expectations are misaligned. Therefore, if generational weaknesses are preferred, it is clear the environment has a role in contributing to expectations in the attrition and retention stages.

Managers highlighted workload unpredictability as a stressor, rather than ‘volume alone.’ Specific to stress, Participant B said "if there is constant stress instead of seasonal pressure, people can't handle it; poor planning, poor communication creates stress." This reflects Unpredictability having a high mean of 4.19 in quantitative data.

However, as determined using a T-test ($p=0.7388$), it is our initial conclusion workload pressure, as it was measured in the present research study, did not appear to be a pressure based on age coding noting there were also differences in the work experience of each group as outlined earlier in this paper thus freeing again, the arguments of fragility on Gen Z.

A striking paradox emerged between the high cost of attrition (33% rate, with 3 months for recruitment and 6-9 months to restore productivity) and managerial resistance to change. Many framed retention as an employee responsibility, stating, "If employees match expectations, good; else companies don’t need them" (Participant A), reflecting a power asymmetry that overlooks organizational design flaws. This resistance persists despite clear evidence of systemic issues, such as poor planning and opaque evaluation processes, which managers themselves admitted contribute to turnover.

Synthesizing qualitative and quantitative findings reveals both convergences and contradictions. Managers correctly identified expectation mismatches, the critical nature of early-tenure retention, and the pivotal role of managerial quality. However, they often misattributed attrition to generational traits rather than organizational failures, such as unclear expectations, poor planning, and rigid work-from-home (WFH) policies. While managers opposed remote work for early-career employees, arguing that "office presence is very important" (Participant A), the quantitative data suggests that inflexible policies may actually increase attrition risk.

The Psychological Contract Violation Framework further contextualizes these dynamics. Employees expect clear career paths, fair compensation, predictable workloads, recognition, and flexibility, yet organizations often fail to deliver. Managers admitted to inconsistencies in promotion criteria, last-minute changes, and inadequate recognition, all of which contribute to broken psychological contracts. When managers provide clarity, feedback, and fairness (Factor 1), attrition risk decreases significantly.

An unexpected finding was the "Recruitment Filter Hypothesis", where Participant B suggested that employees often leave not for better opportunities but to escape organizational baggage, such as accumulated dissatisfaction or rigid policies. This aligns with the moderate mean score for Active Job Search (2.89), indicating that employees explore exits conditionally rather than out of desperation.

Effective managerial solutions, such as mentorship, feedback loops, job rotation, and flexibility, directly map to Factor 1, reinforcing that retention hinges on managerial quality rather than compensation or workload adjustments alone. However, the qualitative data has limitations, including a small sample size ($N = 3$), sector bias (underrepresentation of high-attrition industries like IT/Tech), and potential survivorship bias, as all interviewed managers held stable senior roles. Social desirability may also have led to an underreporting of organizational failures. Despite these constraints, the findings underscore that improving managerial effectiveness is the most impactful lever for reducing attrition.

6. Integrating Managerial and Employee Perspective

The integration of qualitative and quantitative findings reveals a central paradox: managers are both right and wrong in their assessments of early-career attrition. They correctly identify expectation mismatches, the disruptive cost of early-career turnover (0-3 years), and instances of employee underperformance. However, their belief that workload pressure is a "Gen Z problem" is statistically refuted (t-test $p = 0.7388$), with both early-career and senior employees reporting identical pressure levels. Similarly, their assumption that attrition is primarily employee-driven ignores the 85% reduction in attrition risk associated with improvements in Factor 1 (Managerial Effectiveness), demonstrating that organizational practices play a far greater role. The framing of flexibility demands as "entitlement" is also misplaced, as rigid policies appear to exacerbate rather than mitigate attrition risks.

The so-called "Gen Z problem" is better understood as a systemic design failure. Managers often attribute attrition to generational fragility, yet the data reveal universal issues, such as workload unpredictability and poor communication. For example, Participant A's claim that "work-life balance is a Gen Z problem" is contradicted by the statistical absence of generational differences in workload pressure. This misdiagnosis leads to ineffective solutions, such as resilience training, while overlooking root causes like chaotic workloads and unclear expectations. Treating early-career employees as inherently problematic risks creating a self-fulfilling prophecy, where antagonistic manager-employee relationships further erode retention.

At the heart of the issue lies a "clarity deficit", a failure to communicate expectations, provide feedback, and ensure fair evaluations. Participant B's admission that "clarity of work expectation is not there in most places" aligns with quantitative findings: Clarity (mean = 3.31), Feedback (mean = 2.97), and Fair Evaluation (mean = 3.08) all score neutral or below, indicating systemic communication gaps. The high loadings of these variables in Factor 1 (Clarity: 0.89, Feedback: 0.91, Fair Evaluation: 0.84) and their 85% reduction in attrition odds per standard deviation improvement underscore their critical role. When managers address these deficits, as seen in Participant C's near-zero attrition model, retention improves dramatically.

Both data sources converge on a workload predictability crisis, where the issue is not excessive hours but chaotic, poorly communicated demands. Unpredictability (mean = 4.19) and Workload Spikes (mean = 3.44) emerge as key drivers of dissatisfaction, not because employees seek "easy jobs," but because they need temporal stability to manage work and personal life. Proactive resource allocation and advance notice of deadlines could mitigate this issue, shifting organizations from reactive firefighting to structured planning.

The flexibility paradox further complicates the narrative. While managers resist remote work, citing its incompatibility with early-career training ("Office presence is very important" – Participant A), Factor 3 (Autonomy & Flexibility) shows a paradoxical positive relationship with attrition risk. This suggests that flexibility, when implemented without clarity or support, may feel like neglect rather than empowerment. A structured hybrid model, balancing in-office mentorship with remote focus days, could resolve this tension, particularly in India's collectivist culture, where in-person relationships are valued.

A critical yet overlooked factor is the recruitment-retention disconnect. Poor hiring decisions, driven by managerial pressure to fill roles quickly, set the stage for attrition long before onboarding begins. As Participant A noted, "New managers don't know how to do [hiring] properly," leading to skill mismatches that undermine subsequent training investments. Future research should explore whether high-risk employees are truly low performers or high performers frustrated by poor management.

Participant B's success offers a blueprint for retention, built on personalized relationships (Factor 1), clear KRAs (Factor 1), competitive pay (Factor 3), and selective hiring. While scalable implementation remains challenging for large organizations, the model proves that Factor 1 optimization is achievable with the right managerial

capacity. However, resistance to change persists due to power asymmetry, where managers externalize blame ("Employees must adapt to us") rather than addressing structural issues. Reframing retention as a managerial KPI, tying bonuses to team retention rates, could align incentives and drive meaningful change. Ultimately, the data demand a shift from blaming employees to improving managerial effectiveness, the most powerful lever for reducing attrition.

7. Conclusion: A Systemic Approach to Reducing Early-Career Attrition

This study set out to explore the drivers of early-career attrition within India's corporate ecosystem by comparing **managerial perceptions** with **employee-reported realities**. The findings collectively refute the oversimplified narrative that high attrition among younger employees stems from generational fragility. Instead, the evidence points to **organizational design and managerial practice** as the critical levers influencing turnover.

The analysis revealed three recurring dimensions:

1. **Managerial Quality** – encompassing clarity, fairness, and feedback.
2. **Workload Pressure** – relating to unpredictability, burnout, and poor planning.
3. **Job Conditions** – reflecting flexibility, recognition, and compensation fairness.

Among these, Managerial Quality emerged as the strongest retention lever. Employees who reported higher clarity of expectations, timely coaching, and transparent evaluation displayed substantially greater intent to stay. Conversely, chronic unpredictability and inconsistent workload planning eroded satisfaction and accelerated turnover intentions across all age groups.

Qualitative interviews reinforced these results. Managers often attributed attrition to "entitlement" or "impatience," yet simultaneously acknowledged organizational flaws, unclear goal setting, excessive last-minute changes, and outdated evaluation systems. This contradiction underscores a **psychological-contract gap**: employees expect structured feedback and fair evaluation, while managers underestimate how strongly these factors affect retention sentiment.

From a theoretical perspective, the study extends psychological-contract and person–organization-fit theories by emphasizing **managerial communication clarity** as the mediating mechanism between organizational systems and employee retention. Practically, the research suggests that companies should:

- Embed clarity and fairness in managerial training frameworks.
- Redesign workload planning to prioritize predictability rather than intensity.
- Balance flexibility with structured mentorship to sustain engagement.
- Treat retention as a **managerial KPI**, linking team-level attrition metrics to leadership evaluations.

However, these implications are **exploratory, not prescriptive**. The study's limited sample and cross-sectional nature constrain causal inference. Future work should adopt longitudinal and multi-sectoral designs ($N > 200$), integrate HRIS data, and test mediating variables such as trust and perceived fairness.

In summary, early-career attrition in India's corporates is not primarily a generational issue but a **systemic management problem**. Strengthening managerial effectiveness, through structured communication, fair evaluation, and workload predictability, offers the most actionable route toward sustainable talent retention.

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Appendix A: Variable–Survey Question Mapping for Quantitative Survey

Table 1

Survey Question / Item	Variable Name	Response Type

Demographics		
What is your gender?	Gender	Categorical
What is your age group?	Age	Categorical
Years of total work experience	Total_Experience	Continuous
Is this your first job?	First_Job	Binary (Yes/No)
How many organizations have you previously worked at?	Num_Previous_Orgs	Categorical
Which industry does your organization primarily operate in?	Industry	Categorical
Department (Line of service)	Department	Categorical
Tenure at current company (in years)	Tenure	Continuous
Role level	Role_Level	Categorical
Average weekly hours worked	Avg_Hours	Continuous
Total daily commute time (minutes)	Commute_Time	Continuous
Are you a primary caregiver for children or elderly?	Caregiver	Categorical
Are you the primary earning member in your house?	Primary_Earner	Binary (Yes/No)
Workload Perceptions		
I can usually predict my work schedule or targets at least a week in advance.	Schedule_Predictability	5-point Likert
Last-minute changes to tasks or deadlines are common in my role.	Unpredictability	5-point Likert
I experience intense workload spikes that affect my well-being.	Workload_Spikes	5-point Likert

Managerial Quality		
receive helpful coaching or feedback from my manager at least monthly.	Feedback	5-point Likert
My manager gives clear goals and expectations for my role.	Clarity	5-point Likert
Performance evaluations in my team are fair and transparent.	Fair_Evaluation	5-point Likert
Job Conditions		
I have autonomy to choose when I work (start/end times).	Temporal_Autonomy	5-point Likert
I have adequate flexibility about where I work (remote/hybrid options).	Location_Flexibility	5-point Likert
When I request flexibility, it is easy to get approval.	Flexibility_Approval	5-point Likert
My total compensation (base + incentives) is fair for my role and effort.	Fair_Compensation	5-point Likert
Incentive or target rules are clearly communicated and consistently applied.	Compensation_Clarity	5-point Likert
Good performance is recognized in ways that matter to me.	Recognition	5-point Likert
Outcomes		
I often feel emotionally exhausted or burned out because of work.	Burnout	5-point Likert
My current job allows me to maintain an acceptable work–life balance.	WLB	5-point Likert
I expect to be working at this company 12 months from now.	Intent_to_Stay	5-point Likert
In the past month I have actively looked for jobs outside this company.	Active_Job_Search	5-point Likert
Your colleagues have actively searched for other jobs which has influenced you too.	Colleague_Influence	5-point Likert
Qualitative		

What were your main reasons for leaving your most recent job?	Reasons_Leaving	Open-ended
If you could change one thing to make you more likely to stay, what would it be?	One_Thing_Change	Open-ended
Theme (expectation)	Expectation_Theme	Coded category

Note: Likert scale items: 1 = Strongly Disagree, 2 = Disagree, 3 = Neutral, 4 = Agree, 5 = Strongly Agree.

Appendix B: Descriptive statistics of Survey Results

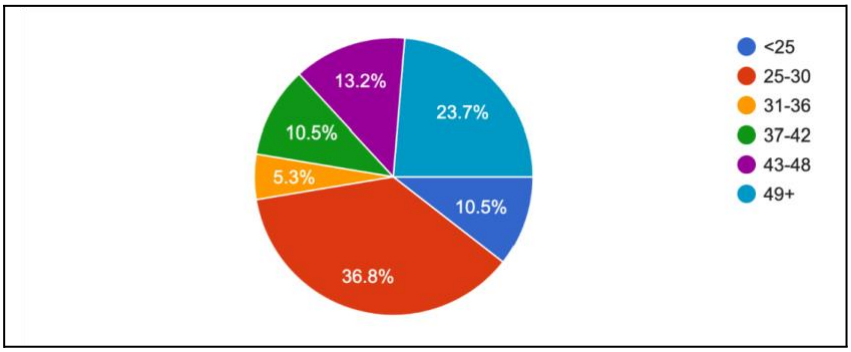


Figure 1 : Age Distribution

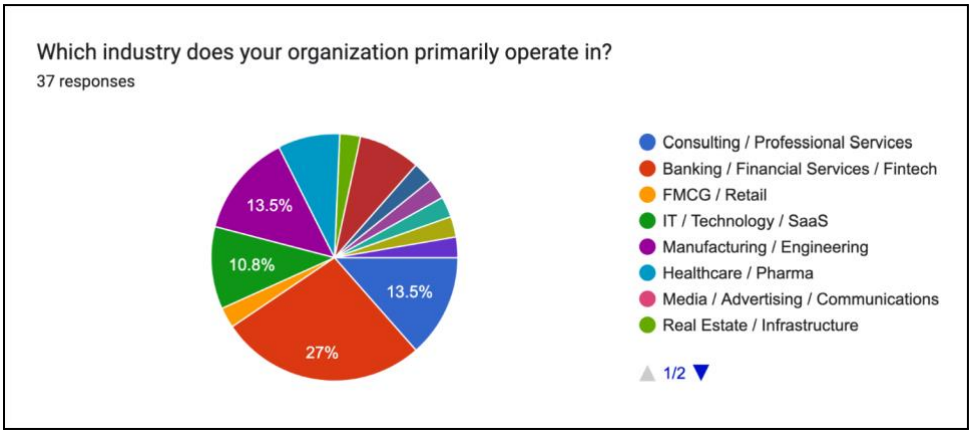


Figure 2: Industry distribution

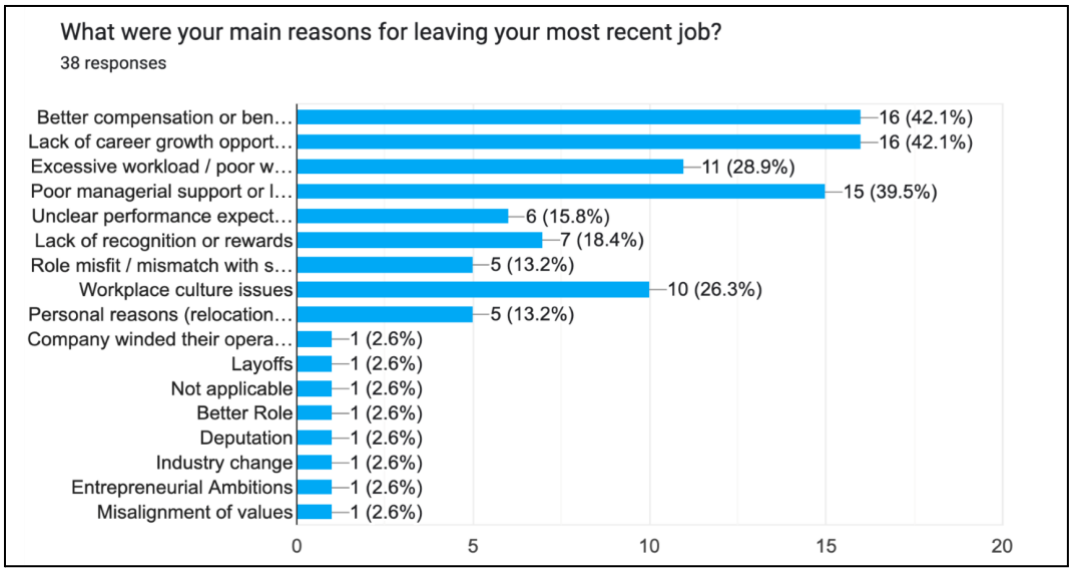


Figure 3 : Employees' Reasons For Leaving Their Last Job

Appendix C: Data Analysis results

Table 6 : Reliability Coefficients (Cronbach's Alpha)

Subscale	***α***	**Interpretation**
Managerial Quality	0.921	Excellent
Workload Pressure	0.509	Questionable
Job Conditions	0.845	Acceptable
Overall Scale	**0.84**	**Good**

Table 7 : Factor Analysis of Likert scale variables

Variable	Factor 1	Factor 2	Factor 3	Primary Factor	Interpretation
Clarity	0.313	-0.030	0.016	Factor 1	Part of managerial quality dimension
Feedback	0.285	-0.097	0.176	Factor 1	Part of managerial quality dimension
Predictability	0.241	0.257	-0.033	Factor 2	Relates to workload predictability and stability
Unpredictability	-0.106	0.551	0.037	Factor 2	Strong indicator of workload unpredictability and pressure

Workload_Spikes	-0.182	0.488	-0.166	Factor 2	Key component of workload pressure and variability
Autonomy	0.221	0.243	-0.477	Factor 3	Strong negative loading indicates relationship with individual stress/autonomy issues
Flexibility	0.272	0.255	-0.072	Factor 1	Part of job conditions and flexibility dimension
Flexibility_Approval	0.325	0.079	0.028	Factor 1	Part of managerial support dimension
Fair_Evaluation	0.306	-0.072	0.169	Factor 1	Part of managerial quality and fairness dimension
Fair_Compensation	0.250	-0.015	-0.089	Factor 1	Part of job conditions dimension
Incentive_Clarity	0.307	0.020	0.183	Factor 1	Part of managerial clarity dimension
Recognition	0.314	0.004	0.206	Factor 1	Part of managerial quality dimension
Variable	Factor 1	Factor 2	Factor 3	Primary Factor	Interpretation
Burnout	0.000	0.423	0.669	Factor 3	Strong indicator of individual stress and burnout, loading on both Factor 2 and Factor 3
WLB	0.268	0.166	-0.380	Factor 3	Relates to work-life balance and individual stress

Table 8 : Descriptive statistics

Aspect	**Early-Career (≤36 years)**	**Senior (37+ years)**	**Interpretation**
Sample Size (n)	20	18	Both groups have similar sample sizes, though slightly unbalanced. Small sample sizes limit statistical power.
Mean (M)	-0.065	0.073	Means are very close to zero, indicating similar average workload pressure across groups.

Standard Deviation (SD)	1.676	0.697	The Early-Career group shows more variability in workload pressure scores compared to the Senior group.

Table 9: Shapiro-Wilk test and Levine test

Test	**Early-Career**	**Senior**	**Interpretation**
Shapiro-Wilk Test for Normality	p = 0.3520 (Normal)	p = 0.0250 (Non-normal)	Early-Career data is normally distributed, but Senior data violates normality assumption.
Levene's Test for Equality of Variances	-	p = 0.0142	Variances are unequal between groups, violating homogeneity of variance assumption.

Note: These assumption violations necessitated the use of Welch's t-test, which does not assume equal variances.

Table 10: Welch's t-test

Test	**Statistic**	**p-value**	**Effect Size**
Welch's t-test	t = -0.3371	p = 0.7388	Cohen's d = -0.105

No statistically significant difference in workload pressure between groups ($p > 0.05$).
The negligible effect size ($d = -0.105$) indicates minimal practical difference between groups.

Table 11: Final results

Finding	**Statistical Evidence**	**Substantive Interpretation**	**Practical Implications**
No significant generational difference	p = 0.7388	Workload pressure is a systemic issue affecting all employees regardless of age group.	Organizations should implement universal interventions rather than age-specific strategies.
Negligible effect size	Cohen's d = - 0.105	The small difference in means (Early-Career: -0.065, Senior: 0.073) has minimal practical significance.	Focus should be on organization-wide policies to address workload pressure rather than targeting specific age groups.
Greater variability in Early-Career	SD = 1.676 vs. 0.697	Early-Career employees experience more variability in workload pressure.	While interventions should be universal, Early-Career employees might benefit from more flexible support systems.

Table 12: Logistic Regression Results Predicting High-Risk Attrition

Predictor	Coefficient	Odds Ratio	p-value
(Intercept)	-2.3518	0.095	0.012
Factor 1 (Managerial Quality and Job Conditions)	-1.1071	0.331	0.005
Factor 2 (Workload Pressure)	0.2578	1.294	0.499
Factor 3 (Individual Stress and Autonomy)	1.0781	2.939	0.080

Table 13: Logistic Regression Results Predicting High-Risk Attrition

Metric	Value
Accuracy	**0.868**
Precision	**0.800**
Recall	**0.727**
F1-Score	**0.762**
ROC-AUC	**0.946**